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State Information Technology Agency (SITA) and the Paradox of Centralized ICT Procurement: Reform or Redundancy in South Africa's Public Sector

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ABSTRACT

Centralized ICT procurement is promoted as a means to improve efficiency and accountability, yet it often generates rigidity and frustration in developing-country contexts. This study investigates this paradox using South Africa's State Information Technology Agency as an example affected by the broader challenges of digital governance in the Global South. Using an interpretivist, abductive approach, 55 semi-structured interviews with Government Information Technology Officers were analyzed thematically. Four patterns emerged: bureaucratic inefficiency, misalignment with departmental needs, workaround behavior and declining institutional legitimacy. These themes informed a Governance-Implementation Feedback Model explaining how control-oriented procurement systems produce institutional erosion and adaptive resistance. The study extends Policy Feedback and Institutional Theory to information systems governance, demonstrating how negative administrative experiences reinforce path dependence. It contributes theoretical and policy insights into balancing oversight and agility within public-sector digital transformation.

Keywords

State Information Technology Agency, public procurement, ICT governance, centralization, Government Information Technology Officers, South Africa; policy feedback

INTRODUCTION

Across much of the Global South, governments have set up centralized ICT agencies, partly to rein in scattered procurement systems, partly to standardize infrastructure and, at least in theory, to limit opportunities for corruption. In practice, these agencies often are driven by competing motives, that is, efficiency ambitions and political compromise, suggesting that consolidation serves both to control spending and to signal modernization. Recent Information Systems (IS) research shows that these arrangements frequently reproduce the very inefficiencies they aim to prevent, generating bureaucratic rigidity, limited innovation and fragmented accountability (Latchu & Singh, 2025a, 2025b).

South Africa's State Information Technology Agency (SITA) sits at the center of government ICT operations. It is the statutory body responsible for overseeing government procurement, connecting departmental systems and protecting public-sector networks. On paper, that setup sounds rational, almost elegant, as a single authority can be expected to ensure order and security in a notoriously messy digital environment. But anyone who has interacted with it knows the picture is not quite so uncomplicated. The actual implementation of these systems shows how responsibilities overlap, and how budget considerations and political factors, together with existing systems, create inconsistencies in the original purpose of the larger ecosystem. What looks like a streamlined structure in policy documents often feels, on the ground, like a patchwork held together by good intentions and outdated cables. The agency's highly centralized model often seems to slow down the very innovation it is supposed to enable. Functioning under the Department of Public Service and Administration, SITA is similar to national ICT agencies in several other developed and developing nations such as India's National Informatics Centre and Kenya's ICT Authority. Thus it is an example of a broad institutional model of centralized digital-governance implementation.

The State Information Technology Agency (SITA) Act 88 of 1998 (as amended 2002) established a statutory agency to centralize ICT procurement and management across South Africa's public sector. It started with modest goals, namely to stop departments from reinventing the wheel and building their own very similar systems, and most crucially, to ensure improved information exchange by linking government databases effectively. Hence, initially this was not a grand vision for digital transformation; it was about addressing the everyday operational challenges arising from duplication including the cost involved, and it was intended to strive for interoperability, standardization, and the enforcement of strong security measures across departments (Republic of South Africa, 1998; 2002). Over time, SITA's role extended well beyond just operational issues. It began to regulate the ICT ecosystem throughout government by setting ICT and cybersecurity standards, approving departmental systems and managing transversal procurement. Hence SITA was considered by some critics to have departed from its original role of service provider and became a gatekeeper for government technology. The change brought order in some respects, but also left many departments exasperated as they waited for approvals. In theory, combining oversight with disaster-recovery duties appeared to be straightforward, but in practice, the arrangement quickly revealed layers of complication. While SITA plays a centralised procurement role, accountability for ICT procurement decisions remains vested with the relevant accounting officer/authority (National Treasury, 2009).

The SITA Act and its associated regulations require SITA to deliver a wide range of ICT services to government departments as shown in Figure 1.

Figure 1**Mandated Services Provided by SITA to Government Departments**

(Adapted from State Information Technology Agency, by Slideserve, n.d.
(<https://www.slideserve.com/liz/state-information-technology-agency>)).



The South African public sector offers a fascinating, and admittedly messy environment for examining how centralized ICT procurement actually works. It is a bureaucracy that reflects the institutional complexity typical of a developing country with overlapping governance layers, statutory mandates that sometimes contradict one another, and a reliance on formal procedures. SITA is the controlling entity as the officially mandated body for ICT acquisition. That makes it a useful vantage point for seeing how centralization plays out in real life, how policy intentions meet organizational routines, and how ideal governance structures can clash with day-to-day realities. The agency's pervasive involvement across departments allows a close examination of the institutional tensions, adaptive practices and legitimacy struggles that define public-sector ICT governance in South Africa.

The agency thus exemplifies the *centralized digital-governance model* promoted in many developing economies, where governments seek efficiency and probity through consolidation of ICT resources under a single coordinating body (Ndou, 2004). However, the actual execution of this requirement continues to encounter difficulties in practice. SITA's procurement system has gradually expanded to include an ever increasing number of procedures and compliance steps. What was meant to keep things under control now often results in projects being subjected to long delays and rigorous supply-chain checks, and as a result there has been a slow response to new technology (Komna & Mpungose, 2024; Mkhonza & Mpungose, 2025). Audit reports, and even inquiry findings, seem to tell the same story. As shown in the Zondo Commission's findings, Latchu and Singh (2024a, 2024b) argue that poor oversight

and repeated breakdowns turned an accountability process into yet another obstacle to getting things done.

There is a recognizable pattern here that can be related to a broader context. Across much of the Global South, information systems governance frameworks that aim to enforce compliance may actually end up stifling digital change. The more these systems strive to control the processes, the less room there seems to be for adaptation or initiative on the ground. However, while the centralized model often faces criticism for limiting flexibility, advocates justify it on both theoretical and managerial grounds. The logic seems sound; centralizing ICT procurement should indeed deliver fairness, improve oversight of vendors, and lower costs through economies of scale, but real outcomes tend to be less predictable. Therefore, as the Auditor-General keeps reminding us (Latchu, 2022), those promises rarely come to fruition despite the fact that they are the intended goal of statements in the policy documents. Procurement planning tends to be complex. The processes required to implement new policies face delays in part because there is weak oversight and also because deadlines are frequently pushed back. The difference between policy promises and government office realities has regularly been evident as forms accumulate and approvals are postponed because competing priorities silently undermine all planned initiatives.

Studies of the Integrated Financial Management Information System (IFMIS) in Kenya have shown how policy objectives clash with the real operational practices of the government. The relatively new IFMIS provides unprecedented transparency in government spending because it tracks financial transactions and maintains digital records (Abdullahi & Musau, 2025). The system has achieved this goal according to Mutangili (2025), but nevertheless it has not fundamentally transformed the practices or organizational structures that determine daily financial management. The system is reported to face technical challenges because of a lack of widespread expertise resulting in non-uniform deployment as various departments struggle to adapt to the system. Therefore, in some ministries it functions fairly well, but in others it is considered to be just another administrative burden (Kipruto et al., 2024).

The e-government procurement system of Zambia demonstrates comparable lessons. The system was designed to make operations more efficient while guarding against political interference, but it encountered resistance from already well-established practices of control and delay (Mweshi & Kabamba, 2025). The code itself did not seem to be the root of the problem, instead the issues stemmed from the cultural environment surrounding it. Hence, system implementation alone does not lead to real change; institutions need to transform their core operational patterns which affect actual system adoption. Scholars attribute weaknesses in the implementation and sustainability of projects to structural and institutional factors. These factors include opposition to rigid regulatory conditions, a lack of qualified staff, as well as high turnover of employees (Mkhonza & Mpungose, 2025). In addition, in South Africa the executives of the departments may feel marginalized since they have been forced to adopt SITA and Treasury processes rather than employing their own capacities to make strategic decisions (Latchu & Singh, 2025b). The dilemma between the imposition of central control of authority and permitting flexibility in the operation of IS governance supports the ongoing debates in IS research on governance centralization and local freedom of operations (Ngwenyama, 2019).

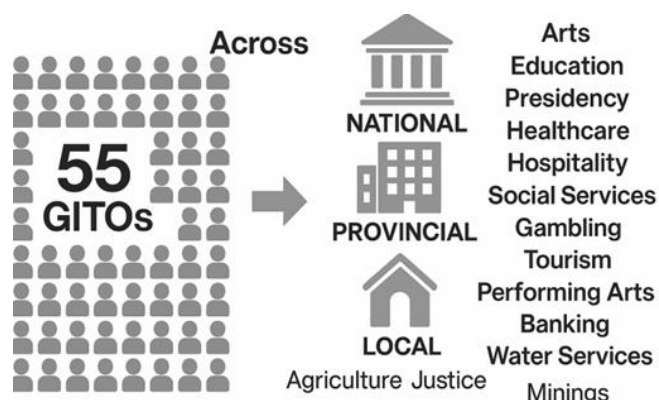
These discussions regarding reform are increasingly focused on how to strike a workable balance between oversight and flexibility. Indeed the SITA Amendment Act (2002) already hinted at this tension, as it gave departments some legitimate ways to bypass central procurement, though only with formal approval. Current discussions appear to promote this view further, suggesting hybrid models that keep central coordination intact while also giving departments some opportunities to act rapidly (Komna

& Mpungose, 2024). Evidence from elsewhere lends credibility to this approach. The Digital India initiative shows how decentralization of ICT operations across the levels of government can improve access and inclusion using decentralized systems but emphasizes that this scheme relies on adequate support in the form of local infrastructure and skills development (Gajendra & Jena, 2025, Sindakis & Showkat, 2024). The South African experience, which relies on the help of Government Information Technology Officers (GITO), is no exception, it exhibits a similar pattern but nevertheless has its own peculiarities. Informal agreements that are flexible as opposed to standard rule adherence are significant in the success of projects since they encourage the formation of partnerships, but this requires the ability to make minor compromises in order for the project to become sustainable (Latchu & Singh, 2025b). The experience obtained from these cases indicates that reform initiatives should avoid strict adherence to doctrine. The pursuit of a perfect model should be replaced by flexibility which enables local decision-making based on real-world governance practices instead of theoretical guidelines.

The institutional dynamics are clearly depicted in Figure 2 which shows the empirical research on which this paper is based. Figure 2 depicts the government levels (starting from national down to provincial and local institutions) whose digital governance and procurement processes were studied.

Figure 2

Illustration of GITO Study (Source: Latchu & Singh (2025b))



In sum, the outcomes of the SITA Act illustrate the dual nature of South Africa's governance instruments; strong in design yet weak in execution. More broadly, research suggests that centralized ICT procurement in its current form is unlikely to advance digital transformation meaningfully in developing countries (Latchu, 2022; Latchu & Singh, 2024a; Mutangili, 2025; Mweshi & Kabamba, 2025; Ndou, 2004). Noticeable progress appears possible only if such systems are reformed in such a way as to balance procedural integrity with a degree of flexibility; or put differently, if probity is matched with agility.

The research described in this paper investigated how SITA and similar agencies affect digital governance effectiveness and information systems performance in the public sectors of developing countries through their centralized ICT procurement processes. The research positions SITA within the Global South e-government and ICT governance framework and hence expands information systems knowledge about institutional capacity and public sector digital transformation challenges and governance reform initiatives.

LITERATURE REVIEW AND CONCEPTUAL BACKGROUND

Information Systems Governance in the Public Sector

Modern governance depends heavily on information systems (IS) to achieve efficiency and transparency, and to maintain accountability. Over several decades, public sector operations have undergone a continuous and in many cases radical transformation because IS systems can now support planning, service delivery and performance monitoring. The Global South has accelerated its digital governance systems development through ICT-based reforms which focus on using technology to enhance operational efficiency and accountability (Ndou, 2004). However, the public sector in Africa continues to face high failure rates for IS projects even though they have become common throughout the continent (Latchu & Singh, 2024a). The theoretical soundness of governance frameworks is contradicted by the implementation challenges that result from inadequate institutional coordination and weak execution.

This conflict is also evident in South African government ICT projects. The Public Finance Management Act (PFMA, 1999), the Corporate Governance of ICT Policy Framework (CGICTPF) and the State Information Technology Agency (SITA) Act form the foundation for the governance framework, and aim to achieve high levels of compliance, strategic alignment and probity. However, as research evidence has shown, these control systems have unforeseen consequences as they create administrative barriers that hamper the digital transformation process rather than facilitating it (Latchu, 2022; Latchu & Singh, 2024b). There is strong evidence that the principles of design and the practice of implementation do not work well together in the Global South. Kenya and Zambia have similar administrative structures and also experience delays in their procurement that extend the project time to an unacceptable degree since the agencies in those countries cannot coordinate their operations (Mutangili, 2025; Mweshi and Kabamba, 2025).

The implementation of IS governance in public administration creates a persistent structural problem because systems intended for control and accountability generally limit both organizational flexibility and innovation. Effective IS governance needs equilibrium to be maintained between control measures and flexibility, yet developing nations struggle to reach this balance because their institutional resources remain limited (De Haes & Van Grembergen, 2009; Weill & Ross, 2004). Latchu and Singh (2025b) extend this argument by showing that the GITOs navigate these tensions through adaptive leadership, coalition-building and negotiated compliance, that is, by incorporating behaviors not identified in traditional governance models.

Centralized ICT Procurement and its Paradoxes

The centralization of ICT procurement is often justified by the need to achieve economies of scale, standardization and oversight (Komna & Mpungose, 2024; Thai, 2001). However, the current governance systems often fail to achieve their intended goals because their control systems prevent organizations from learning from experience and adapting to new situations. The functions originally intended to facilitate oversight have been found to transform into bureaucratic control which limits managerial flexibility at critical moments of organizational change. Control still matters, of course. The issue is that the balance between holding people accountable and also giving them the freedom to act timeously and decisively has tilted too far in favor of red tape. SITA stands out as a case which demonstrates this contradictory situation very clearly. The establishment of SITA aimed to simplify ICT procurement operations while uniting departmental systems under a single framework. Unfortunately,

the organization has developed a reputation for handling requests unreasonably slowly, its service desk is perceived as being unhelpful, and its environment is also blamed for discouraging fast implementation of new ideas (Latchu & Singh, 2024b).

The same pattern is detectable throughout different systems. The national ICT agencies in India and Kenya received funding to coordinate e-government services but their efforts have been described as creating additional bureaucratic hurdles instead of solving fragmentation issues (Gajendra & Jena, 2025; Mutangili, 2025). Research reports on IS development in developing countries say that procurement systems based on control and compliance fail to support the adaptive nature of ICT projects (Mweshi & Kabamba, 2025; Ndou, 2004). These systems' accountability mechanisms have had an unforeseen outcome which hinders systems from becoming more responsive even though they aim to enhance efficiency. Published research findings indicate that centralization for accountability purposes inevitably leads to reduced innovation and system responsiveness because oversight systems lack appropriate supportive policies and do not rate technical expertise sufficiently highly.

According to Latchu and Singh (2024a) institutional rigidities emerge naturally from governance systems which choose to prioritize risk avoidance over performance delivery. The problems SITA faces represent a broad pattern in the Global South where institutions can demonstrate compliance through formal processes but are unable to develop new operational capabilities.

Theoretical Perspectives: Institutional and Policy Feedback Lenses

The persistence of governance systems despite their evident inefficiencies can be explained by institutional theory because survival is now considered to be the primary indicator of legitimacy. According to Scott (2014) institutions maintain their existence by reliance on three pillars which enforce compliance - these are regulative, normative and cultural-cognitive processes. The pillars of ICT governance promote ongoing stability through established procurement rules, standardized requirements and mandatory compliance checks.

Policy feedback theory builds upon this concept by demonstrating how policies establish automatic feedback systems that encourage actors to maintain their current behavioral patterns (Hacker & Pierson, 2014; Pierson, 1993). Over time, procurement policies that are intended to ensure fairness generate procedural complexity that inhibits reform. Drawing on this insight, Latchu and Singh (2025a) show that once centralized ICT systems are adopted they are hard to change; even when it is clear they are not working efficiently, the systems keep functioning in the same way.

The micro-level theories of Street-Level Bureaucracy (Lipsky, 1980) and Institutional Work (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006) reveal how actors cope with institutional barriers through their actions. The South African case shows how GITO's perform institutional work through rule interpretation, negotiation and improvisation in order to achieve ICT delivery goals (Latchu & Singh, 2025b). The actions of ICT leaders show how they learn to satisfy the organizational control requirements, performance needs and innovation demands by managing the complex relationship between structure and agency. Public-sector ICT management requires hybrid governance systems which recognize that discretion and agency function as fundamental elements of their operations.

Conceptual Gap and Study Positioning

Research on ICT governance and public-sector procurement has not produced a single, unified model which explains how governance structures and procurement systems affect information systems'

performance in developing countries. Research still tends to focus on studying technical governance systems and individual implementation breakdowns separately from each other.

This study helps to close that gap by connecting the abstract concepts found in institutional and policy feedback theories with evidence of what actually happens inside centralized ICT procurement systems. The SITA case serves as an example which demonstrates how accountability-focused governance systems create conditions that lead to persistent inefficiencies and stagnation. The research combines Public Administration knowledge with IS research to develop a Governance-Implementation Feedback Model which demonstrates how rules influence conduct and practitioners modify these rules to maintain operational effectiveness.

Following the approach outlined by Schryen et al. (2020), this study reviews what the field has already learned, challenges some of its central assumptions, and offers fresh points of view that could move current research forward. It weaves together different strands of IS literature; these focus on governance, digital change and institutional adaptation, especially as these play out in developing contexts. What stands out from earlier work is that South Africa's recurring ICT governance problems do not fit neatly within a single theoretical framework. They appear to be the product of overlapping institutional, behavioral and policy dynamics.

These dynamics form a web of interdependence: policies shape behavior, institutional routines reinforce policy choices, and both converge to influence how a centralized agency such as SITA performs in practice. Institutional Theory helps to explain why centralized systems stagnate despite repeated reform attempts that seem to have promised structural change. Institutional Theory points to deeper path dependencies, such as habits, interests and power relationships, that make the status quo remarkably resilient. Policy Feedback Theory together with Public Procurement Theory helps to explain why regulation and centralization so often reinforce one another, producing systems where compliance overshadows innovation. Implementation Theory broadens this view, revealing how institutional barriers can turn carefully designed reforms into something quite different from what was intended once they are implemented. The Street-Level Bureaucracy and Institutional Work perspectives explain how ICT officials use their agency to work within strict organizational frameworks; this leads to both the maintenance of existing structures and to minor modifications to them. The research framework of this study demonstrates how governance design and practitioner adaptation can interact to create long-lasting institutional decline.

Figure 3*Integrated Theoretical Framework for Understanding SITA's Institutional Dynamics*

(Source: Authors own)

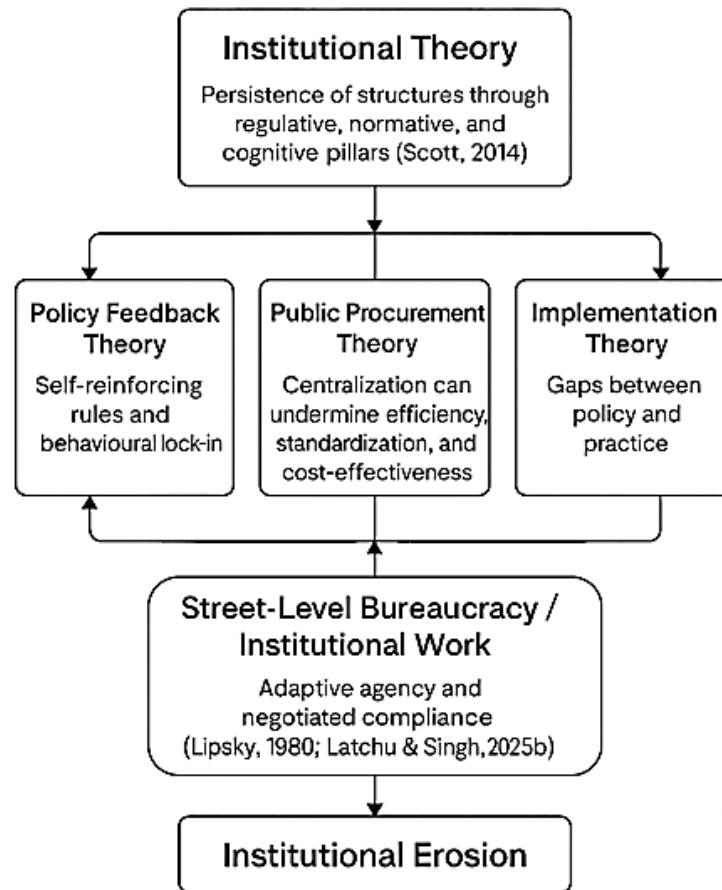


Figure 3 integrates four complementary perspectives to explain how governance design, procurement mechanisms and implementation behavior have interacted to erode institutional competence within SITA's centralized ICT procurement model. Institutional Theory (Scott, 2014) suggests that governance structures persist largely because they are reinforced through both formal regulation and shared expectations. Policy Feedback Theory (Hacker & Pierson, 2014; Pierson, 1993) extends this view, showing how compliance practices can become self-perpetuating and, at times, foster avoidance behaviors. From a public-procurement perspective, excessive centralization in the name of accountability appears to reduce efficiency and lessen an organization's ability to respond quickly to changing needs. Implementation Theory explains that policy goals fail to materialize because the organization lacks necessary resources and the reward system does not match the objectives. Micro-level analyses of Street-Level Bureaucracy and Institutional Work reveal how adaptive agency and negotiated compliance become entrenched over time and influence institutional persistence and decay patterns (Latchu & Singh, 2025b; Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Lipsky, 1980). Collectively, the framework

depicts a cyclical process in which structure and agency interact, sustaining governance rigidity and constraining digital-transformation outcomes.

METHODOLOGY

Research Paradigm and Assumptions

This study was aligned with the interpretivist paradigm, which assumes that organizational and governance realities are socially constructed through the meanings and actions of individuals rather than existing as objective facts to be measured (Klein & Myers, 1999; Walsham, 1995). The ontological approach adopted considers the way in which public-sector ICT governance should be analyzed, taking into account the institutional phenomena existing in the given context, how governance is impacted by existing norms and power relations, and how these jointly affect a practical application of public-sector ICT governance. The epistemology reflects the researcher's need to understand how the respondents who participated in the research felt about and practiced governance daily. This was appropriate since the study focused on the experience of and implementation by GITCs of centralized procurement systems. In line with this interpretive stance, the study employed abductive reasoning (Sarker et al., 2013) to iteratively connect empirical insights with a theoretical explanation, allowing the emergent Governance-Implementation Feedback Model to reflect both institutional structures and practitioner sense-making in context.

Research Strategy and Case Design

As indicated above, this work was written on the basis of the interpretivist and abductive philosophy and also followed a qualitative multiple-case design (Walsham, 1995; Yin, 2018). The case study method was appropriate for the study as it aimed to gain in-depth insights into contextualized organizational phenomena, in particular in how governance practices influence the ICT procurement practices in the public sector of South Africa. The unit of analysis used was the set of GITOs who engaged with SITA during procurement, project implementation and strategic ICT decision-making.

SITA functioned as the *central institutional anchor* of the investigation, while the national and provincial departments and public entities represented embedded sub-cases that reflected variations across slightly different contexts. This multiple-case logic enhances analytic generalizability by allowing theoretical replication, that is, observing similar or contrasting patterns across entities (Yin, 2018). Cases were selected purposively to capture diversity in organizational size, function and governance maturity, and because each interacted directly with SITA under the same regulatory framework.

The case boundaries were defined by time (a 24-month data-collection period), context (South African public-sector ICT governance), and participant role (GITOs and equivalent ICT heads). Therefore, the design aligned with the study's abductive logic; empirical insights from each case informed iterative refinement of theoretical explanations, culminating in the development of the Governance-Implementation Feedback Model that can integrate institutional, policy and behavioral perspectives.

Data Collection

The data came from 55 semi-structured interviews with GITOs and ICT leaders representing national, provincial and municipal spheres of government in South Africa. The participants were purposively selected to represent a diversity of institutional sizes, functions and governance maturities. The

interviews were done over 24 months, and the sessions took 60 to 90 minutes each and were transcribed verbatim and recorded.

Open ended questions about ICT procurement processes, experiences of project implementation and experiences with SITA were incorporated in the interview protocol. The perceived efficiency of SITA, autonomy in decision making and workarounds to handle procedural delays were chosen as lines for investigation. To strengthen triangulation and ensure contextual accuracy, the study also drew on documentary sources such as legislation, Auditor-General reports and SITA policy guidelines (Latchu & Singh, 2024b). Ethical clearance was obtained prior to data collection from the University of South Africa (UNISA) School of Computing Research Ethics Committee (Ref #0423, 25 April 2023 - 24 April 2028). Participation in the study was voluntary, and all the participants were assigned numeric codes to ensure anonymity ("Interview 01-55"). These protocols ensured both the credibility and replicability of the dataset, aligning with recognized qualitative research standards (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Yin, 2018).

Data Analysis

The study applied thematic analysis following the six-phase approach outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006). Following transcription, data were read several times so that the researchers could familiarize themselves with the content, and preliminary codes were created inductively. The codes were used to represent the common concepts of engagement, frustration, workaround and adaptation concerning SITA activities. The codes were then grouped into higher-order categories, which were transformed into four major themes, namely inefficiency, misalignment, emergent workarounds and loss of legitimacy.

In order to improve reliability, a review of coding consistency was done jointly by both authors. Triangulation of the patterns that emerged with documentary sources constituted validation of those patterns and interpretive corroboration. The discussion adhered to an abductive logic (Sarker et al., 2013), which alternated between the empirical information and theoretical frameworks (the different theories included the Institutional, Policy Feedback, Procurement and Implementation theories) (Klein and Myers, 1999). The concepts of agency-oriented Street-Level Bureaucracy and Institutional Work were introduced into the analysis to refine the interpretation further.

This was done in a systematic manner, which ensured transparency and traceability that would enable other researchers to replicate or support the findings in similar situations surrounding the governance of ICT in the public sector.

Theoretical categories were narrowed to practice-proximate realities as patterns were identified on the basis of the analysis of the interviews. As an example, a Street-Level Bureaucracy and Institutional Work exposition was introduced as this was considered to be relevant to the issue of negotiation of constraints by ICT officers that emerged inductively in the research. This iterative engagement between theory and data enabled the development of a Governance-Implementation Feedback Model which reinterprets how centralized ICT procurement mechanisms reproduce institutional rigidity while simultaneously enabling adaptive agency. The theoretical approach therefore reflects abductive reasoning, it moves between existing IS governance theories and empirical insights to generate a contextually grounded conceptual contribution.

SITA was explicitly named with institutional permission, as it constitutes a public entity operating under the Public Finance Management Act (PFMA, 1999) and no confidential or proprietary information was disclosed.

Figure 4
Methodology Employed (Source: Authors own)

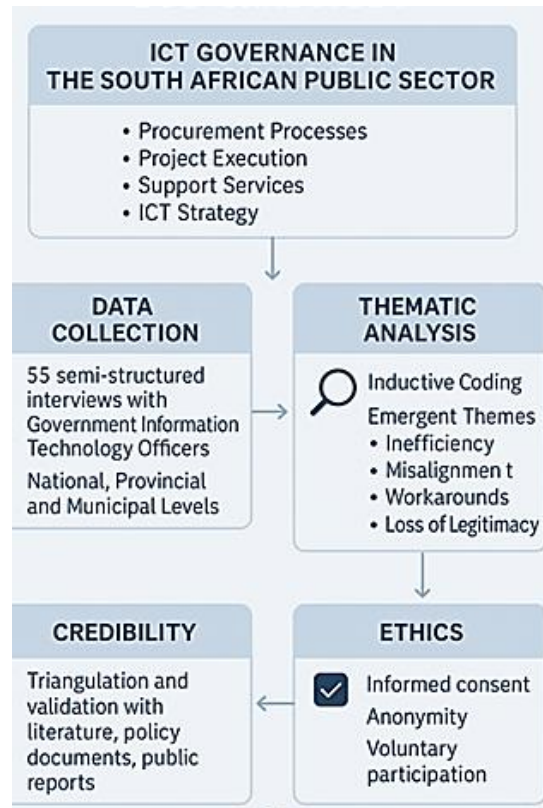


Figure 4 gives a brief description of the qualitative multiple-case research design employed in the investigation of institutional dynamics of ICT governance in the South African public sector. It integrated 55 semi-structured interviews with GITOs at national, provincial and municipal levels in terms of their experience with SITA, ICT procurement roles and adaptive response to inefficiency.

Thematic analysis was conducted with the inductive coding being used to derive patterns of inefficiency, misalignment, workarounds and legitimacy loss, each of which emerged as a central theme in the description of the influence of centralized procurement on implementation. Triangulation with policy reports, audit reports and government publications strengthened the credibility of the research. In addition, adherence to ethical considerations, including informed consent, anonymity and voluntary participation allowed discussion of this sensitive topic.

Figure 4 provides a summary of the procedural aspects that are necessary where an abductive approach will be used to broaden the analysis (Sarker et al., 2013). Based on reading related to the Institutional Dynamics, Policy Feedback, Public Procurement and Implementation theories (Klein and Myers, 1999), more sensitive and nuanced interpretations could be made and the agency perspectives (Street-Level Bureaucracy, Institutional Work) were subsequently introduced as patterns took shape. The resulting data-theory model informed the contextually-based Governance-Implementation Feedback Model, which highlights the association between centralization, adaptation and institutional erosion.

FINDINGS

Case of research: The State Information Technology Agency (SITA) in Context

SITA was set up by the SITA Act 88 of 1998 (amended in 2002) to centralize ICT procurements, and to improve standardization and service delivery in the South African public sector (Republic of South Africa, 1998; 2002). Its original goals were to minimize duplication, foster interoperability, secure data and enable economies of scale in purchasing ICT. National Treasury guidance later reinforced this centralised procurement role, including reducing duplication and leveraging economies of scale through standardisation and certification requirements (National Treasury, 2009). The mandate of SITA made it a statutory broker, which enabled departments to procure transversal ICT systems, private networks and disaster-recovery services (Latchu & Singh, 2024b).

However, over time, SITA ended up revealing the contradictions of centralized governance. Its procurement processes faced widespread criticism due to bureaucratic inefficiency, long lead times, and its inability to align in a satisfactory way with the needs of the departments, although it was supposed to improve accountability and control (Latchu, 2022; Latchu and Singh, 2024a). Audit reports and public inquiries repeatedly identified SITA as a systemic bottleneck, showing that accountability mechanisms can inadvertently produce rigidity and undermine performance (Latchu & Singh, 2024b).

This context offered an empirically rich site for an analysis of how centralization, institutional design and practitioner agency interact within a developing-country bureaucracy. The study's 55 participants were GITOs and ICT heads from national and provincial bodies, who operated at the point where governance rules meet the realities of service delivery. Their encounters with SITA brought to light the behaviors of interest in this study, namely emergent workarounds, negotiated adaptations and the erosion of legitimacy in the governance implementation of ICT procurement (Latchu & Singh, 2025b).

Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency

Almost all GITOs described SITA as excessively slow. One respondent lamented, *"...if only the SITA processes would allow procurement to be within the specific financial years, transversal tenders working and renewed when required..."* (Interview 14). Another echoed this sentiment: *"The SITA Act needs to be reviewed to address challenges experienced when procuring through SITA."* (Interview 19).

The approval bottlenecks, employee turnover in SITA and repetition of procedures that were common in the project often led to lengthening of the project timelines. One of the senior officials said, *"Delayed due to corporate governance unfortunately but costs are within. Delays between units like SCM and SITA affect delivery."* (Interview 40). *"The Act is old and compels departments to procure services through SITA while SITA itself does not have sufficient capacity."* (Interview 19).

Several GITOs mentioned that the ongoing delays were hurting service delivery outcomes. *"ICT procurement [is] expected to be done through SITA, however SITA turnaround time is too long. In some instances, it takes longer than one financial year and affects service delivery."* (Interview 19).

Others noted SITA's sluggish processes meant that technology was only introduced after it was nearing the end of its useful lifecycle: *"Procurement through SITA takes anything between 1.5 to 3 years or longer. SITA procurement executives and leads are always and still on suspension. SITA is not a service-oriented organization. Most of the audit findings are because of SITA. Their delays impact service delivery within the DTIC. They are making Government entities dysfunctional."* (Interview 46).

These results agree with other significant criticisms of the inefficiencies in the South African state sector procurement procedures (Fourie and Malan, 2020) and reflect the flaws of centralized systems of procurement in line with the warnings raised by the Theory of Public Procurement, such as rigidity and deceleration of change that occurs when processes are not modified as fast as ICT requires (Thai, 2001).

Misalignment Between SITA and Departmental Needs

Multiple participants noted that SITA provided standard solutions which failed to accommodate the specific requirements of individual departments. *"The monitoring is generic, not specific to the service SITA offers, hence SITA (what clients get on paper (their monthly reports) and what the clients get) [is] very different."* (Interview 14). One GITO commented, *"SITA affects service delivery. It is a huge hindrance and does not provide economies of scale as it was intended. I would not recommend it."* (Interview 19).

The centrally managed procurement catalogue was considered to be both outdated and rigid. *"We had to run products unsupported (without the ability to upgrade or get support from the OEM). The SITA Act does not work for us"* (Interview 46).

Compounding this issue was a perceived lack of ICT-specific knowledge among SITA's procurement officers. *"SCM don't understand technical requirements, they will take time [to] finalize easy stuff or even reject quotations because [a] different technical name was used... This also wastes time."* (Interview 1). Another participant stressed, *"ICT is barred from engaging with service providers yet SCM, who can, do not understand the product - so it's a recipe for disaster. When SCM does go, they bring in half-baked solutions and during system implementation you see the issues coming out."* (Interview 27).

This seemingly systemic disparity supports the critiques by Mathase et al. (2019) of failures in ICT governance implementation in the public sphere, and is in line with The Cultural Theory of Implementation which describes how failures in design and the lack of ICT-literate personnel jeopardize policy outcomes (Hill & Hupe, 2014).

Workarounds and Exemptions

Most GITOs reported that they were able to find informal ways to side step SITA in order to avoid delays and inefficiencies. *"I am presently busy in two initiatives – requesting Treasury for exemption, and two, I am informing SITA and its oversight Department of the issues... In essence, we are informing and seeking to run certain critical procurement processes through our own internal processes."* (Interview 46). *"At times we have to deviate from SITA service which also requires memos and red tape. I am very concerned about them."* (Interview 41).

Another GITO supported this view, *"Flexibility is needed to deviate from using SITA. SITA sometimes doesn't have resources, yet we have to use them. Critical services should have an option to deviate to ensure the entity works well as opposed to be funneled through SITA."* (Interview 48).

In some cases, frustration was clear : *"If I were to be able to deviate from SITA, I do believe the department would achieve a lot more in terms of its goals and objectives."* (Interview 53). *"We do not use SITA and will never recommend it."* (Interview 24).

Others noted the risk this posed: *“The only government-wide ICT failure at public entities is possibly associated with the SITA Act. This comes in the form of SITA unable to meet its full obligation to government ICT projects.”* (Interview 10).

These evasive behaviors or work-arounds are good examples of responses to negative policy feedback loops (Pierson, 1993), where dysfunctional policy triggers behaviors which undermine the institution further.

Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy

The combined impact of these challenges resulted in a profound decline of trust and legitimacy regarding SITA. The GITOs saw SITA as an obstacle to their mandates or as an outdated formality at best rather than a partner. *“SITA is unable to deliver on its mandate – and for us, especially when it comes to economies of scale. So, we are stuck in a process which is very costly, due to the prescripts...”* (Interview 28).

The interviewees frequently made statements that implied that SITA had become irrelevant because of its weak performance, yet they continued to follow legal requirements that demanded their interaction with the organization. The way participants described SITA revealed important information: *“SITA does not perform on most, if not all fronts. They are not thought leaders. The customer does not come first, and the SITA Act is thrown around to compel us to comply. The pricing in some cases is up to 10x that of market”* (Interview 46).

The GITOs used vivid metaphors to express their disappointment and frustration. These were professionals who, in principle, supported the idea of coordinated procurement (several acknowledged that SITA’s intended purpose was sound). Yet their lived experience convinced them that SITA was not fit for purpose under its current model. One interviewee said, *“I am very concerned about them. Does not work – it is a hindrance and will not recommend it.”* (Interview 41).

The slow delivery of SITA's work resulted in the good work done by other departments receiving minimal recognition because end-users perceived the ICT unit as performing poorly. This situation created tension and finger-pointing which damaged SITA's reputation as is evident in Interview 14, *“The SITA process really negatively affects the IT unit’s performance...They are not willing to change... the clients on paper and what the clients get [are] very different.”*

Some departments had officially requested greater independence in ICT procurement which would allow them to circumvent SITA through legal means. The interviews together with public discussions in process at the time showed that SITA's client departments served as its most severe critics indicating a loss of institutional legitimacy. The widespread distrust among stakeholders demonstrated how negative policy feedback can lead to institutional de-legitimization. A policy that consistently generates adverse effects for its stakeholders creates conditions for policy modification or abolition (Pierson, 1993).

There were GITOs who were of the opinion that SITA had to be completely reformed or completely abolished. *“... areas that need to be reviewed to consider the industry technology changes and Government transformations”* (Interview 45). This paper's title (Reform or Redundancy) reflects the very issue this interviewee addresses.

The erosion of SITA’s authority has had practical consequences. Departments increasingly "do their own thing," leading to the fragmentation and lack of oversight that SITA was supposed to prevent. This

choice creates a vicious circle. A senior GITO explained: “We are informing and seeking to run certain critical procurement processes through our own internal processes.” (Interview 46).

The internal battle that the government was facing with regard to the loss of legitimacy was turned into a public issue by the media as well as in investigations initiated by the parliament. These revealed that failures in the ICT systems had occurred. For example, in 2025 government ministers accused SITA of being the department responsible for service delivery problems when there were high profile system outages in government departments (Thorne, 2025; Moyo, 2025; Ebrahim, 2025; Ndlovu, 2025a; Selane, 2025). In response, the leadership of SITA announced that it intended to improve the situation by using automated procurement and quick delivery of services (Mzekandaba, 2025; Ndlovu, 2025b), but this failed to impress GITOs. The interviewees agreed that only sustained positive performance would rebuild trust and that they had not seen signs that this is happening. Many of the stakeholders felt forced to reduce their dependence on SITA until the company demonstrated better performance. As the central ICT procurement authority, SITA had lost all credibility in the view of its main ‘clients’. The current legitimacy crisis made it uncertain whether the process of making small adjustments would rebuild confidence or whether a complete transformation was necessary.

Table 1:

Summary of Public Criticism of SITA by Ministers and Officials (Source: Authors own)

Publication	Article Title	Main Comments
BusinessTech, (Thorne, 2025)	State IT agency in trouble (14 Nov 2024)	Minister Solly Malatsi ordered a Public Service Commission probe into SITA due to irregular procurement, poor service delivery, and internal inefficiencies.
The Citizen (Selane, 2025)	Schreiber explains persistent ICT failures plaguing Home Affairs offices (20 Jun 2025)	Minister Leon Schreiber cited SITA’s slow response times and lack of system reliability as reasons for ongoing Home Affairs disruptions, described SITA as outdated and obstructive to digital reform.
News24 (Ebrahim, 2025)	‘It becomes tedious’ – Govt mulls changing SITA’s role due to huge delays for services, equipment (17 Feb 2025)	Government considering changes to SITA’s mandate due to consistent delays in delivering ICT services. Minister Malatsi said SITA’s processes are no longer aligned with departmental needs.
TechCentral (Ndlovu, 2025a)	Scopa gives SITA a grilling (29 Jan 2025)	SCOPA lamented the fact that the SITA was still using manual/paper-based systems because it had weak internal controls and was at risk of opportunism. Parliament insisted on more control and digitalization of the procedures of SITA.
ITWeb (Moyo, 2025)	SITA takes flak for delays in digitizing SA courts (3 Apr 2025)	According to Parliamentary Justice Committee (Chair Xola Nqola), SITA was accused of hampering digitization of courts by taking long and lack of connectivity, terming it a major challenge to modernization.

Theme	Verbatim Quote	Interview
Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency	...if only the SITA processes would allow procurement to be within the specific financial years...	Interview 14
Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency	The SITA Act needs to be reviewed to address challenges experienced when procuring through SITA.	Interview 19
Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency	Delayed due to corporate governance unfortunately but costs are within...	Interview 40
Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency	ICT procurement [is] expected to be done through SITA, however SITA turnaround time is too long...	Interview 19
Bureaucratic Delay and Inefficiency	Procurement through SITA takes anything between 1.5 to 3 years or longer...	Interview 46
Misalignment with Departmental Needs	The monitoring is generic, not specific to the service SITA offers...	Interview 14
Misalignment with Departmental Needs	SITA affects service delivery. It is a huge hindrance...	Interview 19
Misalignment with Departmental Needs	We had to run products unsupported... The SITA Act does not work for us	Interview 46
Misalignment with Departmental Needs	SCM don't understand technical requirements...	Interview 1
Misalignment with Departmental Needs	ICT is barred from engaging with service providers yet SCM... do not understand the product...	Interview 27
Workarounds and Exemptions	I am presently busy in two initiatives requesting Treasury for exemption...	Interview 46
Workarounds and Exemptions	At times we have to deviate from SITA service which also requires memos...	Interview 41
Workarounds and Exemptions	Flexibility is needed to deviate from using SITA...	Interview 48
Workarounds and Exemptions	If I were to be able to deviate from SITA...	Interview 53
Workarounds and Exemptions	We do not use SITA and will never recommend it	Interview 24
Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy	SITA is unable to deliver on its mandate... very costly, due to the prescripts...	Interview 28
Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy	SITA does not perform on most, if not all fronts... The pricing in some cases are up to 10x that of market	Interview 46
Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy	I am very concerned about them. Does not work .. it is a hindrance...	Interview 41
Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy	The SITA process really negatively affects the IT units performance...	Interview 14
Distrust and Erosion of Legitimacy	Reform or redundancy... areas that need to be reviewed...	Interview 45

Figure 5
Findings Summarized (Source: Authors own)

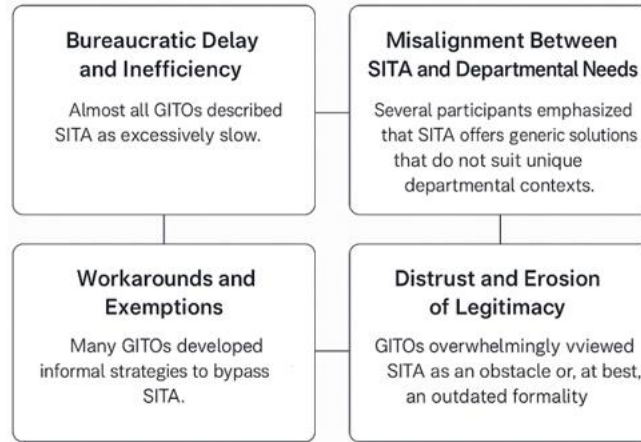


Figure 5 combines visual elements to show the four main themes which the researchers extracted from their analysis of 55 interviews with GITOs. The study's findings revealed that SITA faced deep-rooted, system-wide problems that slowed down or complicated ICT procurement in the public sector. The SITA procurement process received consistent criticism from GITOs for its slow pace and complex procedures which resulted in delivery delays that spanned multiple financial years. The analysis revealed that SITA's standard offerings failed to match departmental technical requirements because the procurement officers lacked the necessary ICT expertise. The inefficiencies at SITA had prompted departments to devise unofficial solutions, or to ask Treasury for exemptions or to bypass the agency completely, thus undermining SITA's coordination function. SITA faced a legitimacy crisis because the combination of delayed processes, mismatched services and strict rules had resulted in extensive distrust among stakeholders.

The legitimacy crisis revealed created obstacles for ICT project completion while endangering the overall goals of unified digital transformation across government entities.

DISCUSSION

It was found that there was a marked tendency to fail to achieve the original goals intended in the context of ICT governance and institutional practice. The information technology practitioners interviewed as a group of professional people were of the view that, instead of organizing and facilitating digital capability, SITA introduced processes that impeded progress in projects and that these were not aligned with the actual needs of operations. These findings are reminiscent of the issues raised by other public administration researchers regarding implementation gaps and their conclusions that capacity constraints and the incompatibility of the formal policies were the root causes of this conflict (Hill & Hupe, 2014; Thai, 2001).

According to the Theory of Public Procurement, centralization is assumed to make processes more efficient by capitalizing on a joint demand and shared expertise pool (Fourie & Malan, 2020). The formation of SITA was based on this rationale and reflected the best international practice reforms of

standardization and cost management. However, centralization has become a point of conflict and not synergy because there is a lack of technical capacity and responsiveness (Latchu, 2022; Latchu & Singh, 2024b). The interviews demonstrated that SITA's rigid processes caused operational delays; this is consistent with other published findings that show that poorly designed central procurement bodies often generate more inefficiency than benefit (Mathase et al., 2019).

As explained by Policy Feedback Theory (Pierson, 1993), negative user experiences in their working with SITA were found to have generated self-reinforcing avoidance behaviors. Eventually many GITOs just gave up waiting for SITA. They found small ways to keep the work going, such as obtaining an exemption, making a phone call, or devising a workaround that had the desired effect without having serious negative side effects. This was not intended to be an act of rebellion, it was simply a means of completing a task made difficult by a system that kept creating barriers. As a result the rules meant to keep everything and everyone accountable started to work against the same goal (Latchu & Singh, 2025b). What remained were disheartened officials, finding whatever space was available and that the system still allowed in which to maneuver, nudging its rules just enough to get something done.

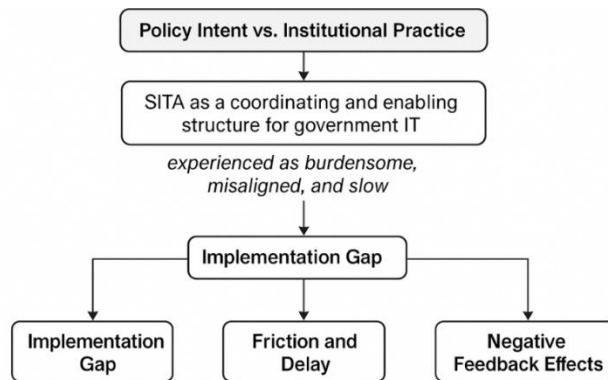
This scenario is not unique to South Africa. Italy's Consip and India's Government e-Marketplace (GeM) have faced similar pushback against centralized procurement systems. The UK's Government Digital Service, on the other hand, seems to have been more successful, though arguably this is because it combined top-down authority with strong technical capability and capacity and consistent political backing (Lotti et al., 2020; Joshi, 2024; Kattel & Takala, 2023). South Africa's case is different; there appears to be a strong message that every compliance box must to be ticked, but there is not nearly enough technical depth to make this a meaningful exercise. With time, the gap described by Komna and Mpungose (2024) as a structural mismatch has slowly eroded SITA's standing and trustworthiness.

According to many GITOs, the challenges require a quiet calculation of risk. How far can you stretch the rules before the system refuses to accept the result? Do you wait for months and risk project paralysis, or do you find a workaround and hope the auditors are forgiving? Most seem to have chosen the latter, not because they were trying to rebel, but simply because this was the only way to get things done. However, each workaround undermines the procurement system a little more, leaving it weaker and much harder to repair.

It is hard not to predict that the pattern that Latchu and Singh (2024a, 2025a, 2025b) pointed out continues to be repeated. Possibly the real problem is not that people ignore the rules, but the way the rules limit the ability of the people responsible for systems delivery to seek and implement the best solution quickly. Layers of approval and paperwork, once meant to protect public value, have slowly turned into something else, a kind of gridlock that strangles the very ICT leadership the state keeps asking for. Collectively, these studies point to a dual tension between control and flexibility, and between structural authority and adaptive agency, which define the South African public sector's digital transformation dilemma.

Figure 6*The Divergence Between SITA's Policy Intent and its Institutional Reality*

(Source: Authors own)



The gap between what policy aims for and what actually happens inside SITA is shown in Figure 6. SITA is meant to coordinate and support government IT, yet over the years many practitioners have come to see it as slow, out of sync with their needs, and often more of an obstacle than a help. This conflict produces an implementation gap, i.e., a recurring failure of formal policy to translate the stated goals into effective practice due to contextual and capacity constraints.

As Figure 6 suggests, this gap shows up in two main ways: firstly, as disagreement between stakeholders and delays in ICT procurement, and secondly, in a feedback loop where frustrated users start finding ways to avoid the system altogether. These adaptive behaviors further erode SITA's legitimacy, reinforcing a self-perpetuating cycle (a vicious circle) of institutional underperformance and mistrust.

Theoretical Integration and Propositions

The four empirical themes, namely, inefficiency, misalignment, emergent workarounds and loss of legitimacy, are mutually reinforcing elements in the governance-implementation feedback loop. Synthesized abductively, they form the foundations of a governance implementation that links structural design to behavioral adaptation.

Four theoretical propositions can be drawn from this model,:

1. **Centralization and Inefficiency:** When everything must pass through a central authority, so called red tape builds up, response times stretch and the space for creative or adaptive solutions shrinks.
2. **Misalignment and Discretion:** When central mandates fail to reflect departmental realities, practitioners tend to rely on informal judgment and workaround tactics to keep projects moving forward.
3. **The Adaptation Paradox:** Improvised solutions may keep operations functioning to some extent in the short term, but over time these measure entrench fragmentation and make lasting reform increasingly difficult.

4. **Erosion of Trust:** The declining legitimacy of the procurement system fosters disengagement and weakens collective accountability.

These propositions build on Institutional and Policy Feedback Theory, showing how systems of control and everyday adaptation evolve concurrently when governance structures are rigid and resources are inadequate (Latchu & Singh, 2025a, 2025b). The Governance-Implementation Feedback Model bridges Public Administration and Information Systems theory by explaining how institutional rigidity and practitioner agency interact to shape ICT outcomes.

Integrative Reflection

Together with Latchu (2022) and Latchu and Singh (2024a, 2024b, 2025a, 2025b), this paper advances a contextual theory of adaptive digital governance for developing economies. It suggests that, in the Global South, ICT reform is rarely just a technical exercise. What is needed requires more complex interventions, namely measures to renew institutional capacity, rebuild trust between actors and to authorize the kind of legitimized discretion that allows people on the ground to make sound judgments.

The disconnect between policy goals and institutional practices in SITA is depicted in Figure 6. The original purpose of SITA as a central enabling body for government IT coordination has evolved into a system which practitioners view as slow and burdensome and not meeting departmental needs. The implementation gap shown in Figure 6 has developed when policies looked good on paper but fell apart in reality. This is usually because the employees and lower level systems needed to execute them are just not equipped to do so.

The gap has two major results, delayed ICT procurement processes and workarounds that bypass the system developed by the users. These consequences do additional damage to central ICT governance legitimacy and effectiveness and this in turn makes institutional underperformance patterns more persistent and pronounced.

Implications

Building on the Governance-Implementation Feedback Model and the theoretical propositions outlined earlier, three sets of implications emerge for policy, practice and scholarship.

Policy Implications: The current mandate and structure of SITA requires a thorough re-evaluation. Policymakers should consider the possibility of decentralizing some of SITA's functions through the introduction of a hybrid model. Hence, the government should implement a tiered system which grants a certain amount of procurement freedom to departments that demonstrate capability, while SITA retains responsibility for the essential centralized functions including bulk licensing agreements and security standards. OECD suggests that centralization needs to be focused rather than comprehensive (Busemeyer, 2022). SITA should adopt a client-centric service model in order to remain central as well as relevant. Service-level agreements with client departments, performance targets (including maximum turnaround times), and monitoring by some form of oversight body (possibly Parliament), should be introduced. The procurement regulations need revision so as to increase agility by raising threshold levels and including expanded ICT-specific exemption criteria; this would minimize the need for complex workarounds. The reform of SITA requires policymakers to agree either to make fundamental changes to the mandate of the organization or to disband completely it in order to establish alternative solutions (including departmental consortiums for achieving the original objectives). It is the view of the

authors that the current situation fails to meet South Africa's digital government requirements thus requiring a major decision about SITA's future.

Practical Implications: The situation requires operational solutions to be put in place immediately to meaningfully improve SITA's current performance.

The first step requires SITA and the GITO's to make substantial improvements to their communication channels and feedback systems. The majority of GITO's participating in the study reported that SITA failed to acknowledge their complaints. The establishment of a structured advisory forum that would enable the GITO's to meet regularly with the SITA management for information exchange and solution co-development would help to build trust between the parties.

The organization needs to dedicate resources for SITA capacity development. The organization should employ additional procurement officers with ICT knowledge, and should upskill existing staff to become project managers who can ensure that department requests are attended to properly. In addition SITA could relocate SITA representatives so that they were stationed inside major departments. This would enable SITA's teams to understand the day-to-day operations of a client department better and hence enable them to customize solutions so that they actually addressed the departments' needs.

Urgent attention needs to be given to the enhancement of operational processes as well as the provision of appropriate digital tools. The study revealed that most delays stemmed from procedures that had become entrenched. The implementation of e-procurement systems which allow online submission tracking and vendor management would substantially reduce the need for repeated interactions. Research by Fourie and Malan (2020) demonstrated that digitalization leads to greater transparency and efficiency in South African procurement processes. Automated workflows, together with automated standard purchase vetting using Artificial Intelligence, should be introduced in pilot projects as these technologies have the potential to lead to tangible improvements. A recognition of the need for supply chain management automation is clear from the statements that SITA management has made publicly on the topic (Mzekandaba, 2025).

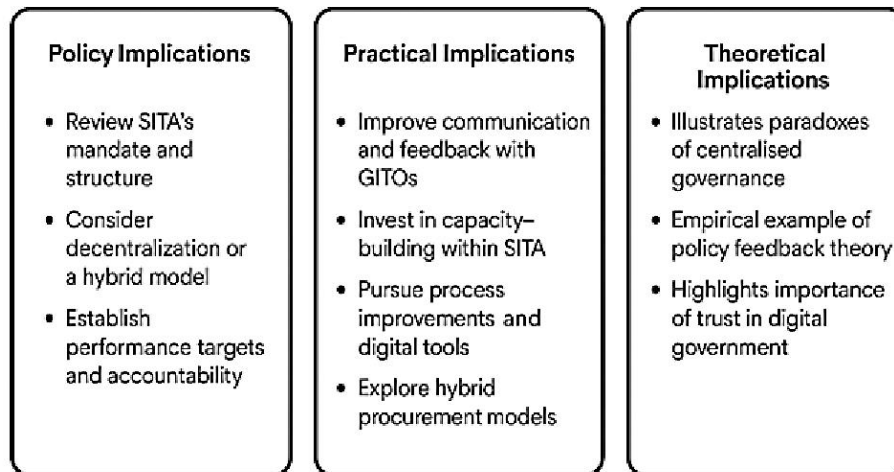
The organization must consider the solutions proposed by various models of procurement that propose a combination of centralized control and decentralized implementation. Departments should have the authority to handle their own procurement within specific limits and SITA (or National Treasury) should only need to participate in evaluation teams as necessary. Such a system would allow departments to benefit from flexibility to improve turnaround times and responsiveness, but importantly SITA still maintains oversight.

The high number of workarounds used currently should be discouraged by updating the governance guidelines to ensure departments uphold fundamental principles of fairness and value. The system should establish detailed procedures for the assessment of Treasury deviation requests to prevent nullifying or reducing the effectiveness of the formal competitive procurement processes. The practical goal is to deliver ICT tools and services on time, using approaches that focus on results without abandoning the safeguards enabled by central system. To create this, SITA will have to revisit the way it perceives itself, including relinquishing the position of gatekeeper and instead adopting a service-partner mentality. Such a change can only be effective when it is spread throughout the organization and becomes a fundamental part of a new organizational culture.

Theoretical Implications: The case presented in this paper can be used to add complexity to arguments about digital government and public administration, and implies that centralized governance, or any other form of governance designed to regulate order and uniformity, can subvert the results it is supposed to promote. The success of such attempts appears to be dependent on the institutional and political circumstances under which they are applied. The present study substantiates the idea that implementation is effective not merely because it is designed well; it also requires the availability of sufficient capacity and user buy-in (Hill & Hupe, 2014). The SITA experience shows that Policy Feedback Theory can be useful in the context of developing countries and where OECD cases prevail, but the application of this theory in these contexts has not received much attention in the literature (Busemeyer, 2022).

According to the case of SITA, negative feedback is more likely to be communicated unobtrusively, typically via informal and unobservable behaviors, rather than through an overt political challenge (Busemeyer, 2022). Researchers should compare SITA with equivalent agencies from other developing nations (including Kenya's ICT Authority and India's central procurement portals) to determine whether similar patterns emerge (Joshi, 2024). Does the same credibility problem affect centralized ICT agencies across different countries or have some of these agencies established legitimate operations? Research through comparative analysis may reveal which institutional elements and contextual factors increase the probability of success or failure. The SITA study demonstrated why building trust is a crucial aspect of creating good intergovernmental relationships. The erosion of trust between SITA and other state institutions effectively undermined their formal partnership. The findings indicated that in public-sector innovation, successful collaboration in achieving good governance depends on preserving a delicate yet crucial balance between establishing trust and demonstrating efficacy. The case illustrated the challenges faced by developing states as they strive to achieve digital transformation while dealing with bureaucratic delays. The reform needs structural changes, investments in human capital, and process improvements to avoid being superficial. These findings add to existing discussions about state capacity during the digital transformation era.

Finally, the study highlights the importance of trust as a foundation for intergovernmental collaboration. The breakdown of trust between SITA and user departments rendered formal partnerships ineffective. For scholars interested in public-sector innovation, this case demonstrates that trust and performance are mutually dependent in collaborative governance systems. Developing nations pursuing digital transformation need to combine structural reform with human-capital investment in order to prevent change from remaining purely cosmetic. These insights add new dimensions to debates on state capacity in the digital-era public sector.

Figure 7*Illustration of Research Implications (Source: Authors own)*

The study results are summarized in Figure 7, which classifies implications as policy, practice or theory.

The **policy implications** indicate that SITA's mandate, and possibly its structure, warrants re-examination. A move toward decentralized or hybrid procurement models may be necessary, provided these are accompanied by clear performance measures and robust accountability mechanisms.

The **practical implications** are equally important. Better communication between GITO's and SITA, increased technical capability inside SITA itself, and the gradual introduction of digital procurement tools and agile management practices could help establish a healthy balance between strategic control and day-to-day responsiveness.

Finally, the **theoretical implications** add to the growing field of digital governance research. The case sheds light on the paradoxes of centralization, shows how Policy Feedback Theory can make sense of these contradictions in a developing-country setting, and underscores the extent to which ICT reform depends on something less tangible, trust in the institutions that drive it.

Collectively, these implications chart a way forward for transforming SITA into a responsive and accountable digital-governance institution capable of advancing South Africa's digital-government strategy.

CONCLUSION

SITA was established to ensure greater order, efficiency and integrity in ICT procurement operations for South African public sector organizations. As the central agency, SITA should prevent wasteful spending while enforcing security standards and providing equitable technology access to all government entities. However, many GITO's are of the opinion that, in their efforts to engage with it, the agency has become an obstacle rather than a facilitator. The documented experiences collected during this study show that the agency faces difficulties in meeting its objectives because of unnecessarily convoluted operations and mismatched services resulting in declining stakeholder confidence. South Africa requires more agile, responsive and strategically aligned procurement systems than ever before as

it works to establish a digitally enabled public sector. The current situation where departments find it necessary to bypass their central agency by adopting workarounds remains unsustainable and counterproductive. The study reveals the common experience of bureaucratic delays, misalignment and legitimacy loss which Hill and Hupe (2014) identify in Implementation Theory as indicating a gap between policy design and execution. The successful delivery of policy directives remains at risk when capacity remains insufficient, incentives do not produce the required performance and responsiveness is judged to be poor. The Public Procurement Theory framework described by Thai (2001) explains why SITA failed to deliver timely and context-sensitive ICT procurement at a cost-effective price; this was because centralization without sound technical knowledge and organizational agility leads to negative outcomes. The research reported in this paper supports the need for the public sector's ICT departments to match their institutional form with the complexity and dynamism of the service that they are expected to deliver. The Policy Feedback Theory (Pierson, 1993) enabled us to gain an insight into how the GITOs' negative experiences resulted in avoidance behaviors that weaken the institution. The workarounds and deviations that have developed, together with passive disengagement, function as institutional drift mechanisms which threaten the legitimacy of centralized procurement. SITA stands at a critical juncture where it must decide between reforming its operations or facing redundancy. The institution must transform itself into a valuable government ICT partner or it will become dispensable because its functions will be transferred to other entities or be performed in entirely different ways. The proposed recommendations demonstrate that reform remains achievable through policy modifications, capacity development and transformation to attain outcome-focused service delivery. There is still enough time for such a reform to be undertaken, but it will eventually expire. Every project delay, every workaround and every indication of GITO exasperation signals that the current system is not working. The SITA case study offers both a warning and a space for learning. When power is centralized without the necessary resources including capability and mutual trust, the system's original objectives are unlikely to be achieved and maintained. The case presents an opportunity to develop new approaches for public sector technology procurement governance in South Africa and comparable developing states. A future SITA or its replacement could fulfill its essential role in South African digital transformation by improving its management of the public ICT investments that are intended to serve citizens. This vision will become a reality through honest recognition of problems and a willingness to make courageous choices, and most importantly by closing the gap between policy goals and actual implementation. The GITOs' accounts gathered in this study are not just observations, they are both a diagnosis of the present problems and a plan for the reforms needed.

Figure 8

Conclusion - Reform or Redundancy? (Source: Authors own)

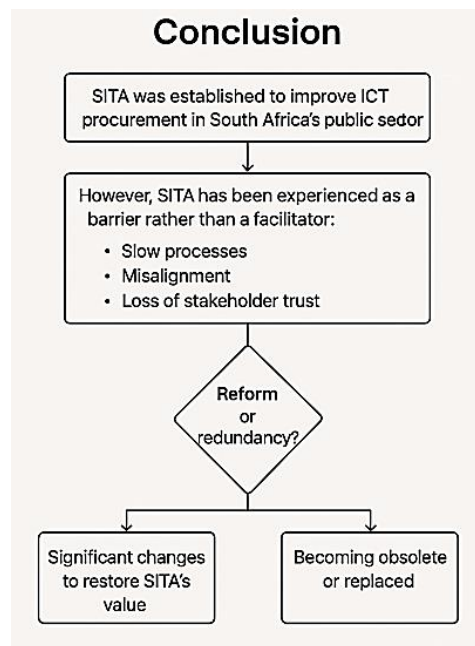


Figure 8 shows how SITA functions as a bureaucratic obstacle which hinders GITOs from doing their work well. SITA is at a critical point because its slow operations, combined with solution misalignment and waning stakeholder trust, have led to this situation.

The figure illustrates two possible paths for SITA: Reform which requires structural changes, a service delivery focus and restoration of legitimacy, or Redundancy which could lead to SITA becoming obsolete and replaced by others bringing in new ways of solving problems. The decision South Africa makes will determine whether SITA drives digital transformation or serves as an example of centralized systems that lack flexibility.

This analysis is directly related to the long-term debate on the effectiveness and use of the South African ICT-governance instruments. Although the legislation, like the SITA Act, PFMA and CGICTPF were meant to harmonize operations and introduce accountability, the results show that it is these regulations that create uncertainty, procrastination, and some variation between interpretations by different departments. This ambiguity is not entirely unforeseeable but is a result of the design of governance and has disproportionate outcomes that practitioners are constantly trying to avoid by bargaining or side stepping them with the help of improvised workarounds. In unearthing this institutionalized uncertainty, and following through on the ways in which it constitutes constraint and agency, the study adds to the evidence on resolving a key question in South African ICT governance: why do these designed instruments of organization so often fail to provide predictable and effective outcomes?

AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

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